

Exquisitely packaged, the Booker Prize winner's second offering is a collection of raw, angry and hungry tales, told with simplicity and a sure-footed irony

■ By Brinda Bose

Before Aravind Adiga's *Assassinations* was allowed to burst upon the world, he had already arrived. And not lightly, either: weighted and feted, a home-born-but-not-bred journalist-turned-writer, the surprise recipient of one of the biggest literary awards of the year. And there is something about Adiga's undoubtedly breathtaking arrival, of the prowled-around-and-pounced-swiftly-from behind variety, that emits a whiff of the nonpareil.

It is indeed curiously fitting in the scheme of fiction—where we are continually searching for an unusual, incredible twist in the tale—that Adiga's debut novel, *The White Tiger*, for which he bagged the Man Booker Prize a couple of weeks ago was not, in fact, his first fictional offering. *Between the Assassinations*, coming so startlingly close on the heels of the Booker now, was ready in 2005 but failed to find a backer, the publishing pundits apparently having decided (surely with some uncannily-self-fulfilling prophetic power) that the very first printing from this talented 34-year-young Chennai-born Mumbaikar should be a novel rather than a collection of short stories. That Adiga is fast proving himself to be a white tiger rather than a white elephant in the fiction industry, with speculation rife about whether his second (first) book might have won him his Booker just as easily as his first novel, will surely not rile his publishers who are, after all, set to laugh loudly all the way to the bank for smiling sales figures the second time within a month in this lean, mean Sensex season. And the new Indian Booker on the block has himself disclosed that one of the first things he will do, post-prize, is look for a safe bank to deposit his cheque in. Given the nose-diving global economy, indeed, it is surely a blessing all around that Adiga chose the right animal to rest his fortunes on.

So, what is this new (old) book all about? Is it a good read? Is it better



BETWEEN THE ASSASSINATIONS
by ARAVIND ADIGA
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EARNING HIS

than his Booker novel? Is it worthy of a Booker winner whose hands are still metaphorically, warm from all that celebratory hand-shaking?

Cross James Joyce's *Dubliners* with R.K. Narayan's *Malgudians*, wrap it in an engaging topographical detail, add some small-town intrigues of class, caste, creed and colour, and spin some arresting tales of gain, loss and irony involving a handful of compelling characters: this, in a nutshell, is Adiga's winning formula for *Between the*

Assassinations, a collection of short stories about the citizens of Kittur, a vibrant little town in the state of Karnataka in south India. This is not to say that Adiga should replace Joyce and Narayan on the canonical shelves of short stories that immortalise a town and its imaginary people, but to identify a genomics of literary lineage. We are not surprised to learn, in other words, that Adiga has been a student of literature in various, and some of the best, universities of the world. This is not to